

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Slav and Semi-Slav

Structures, development schemes, tactical breaks, and Black's freeing play

COURSE BOOK

19 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

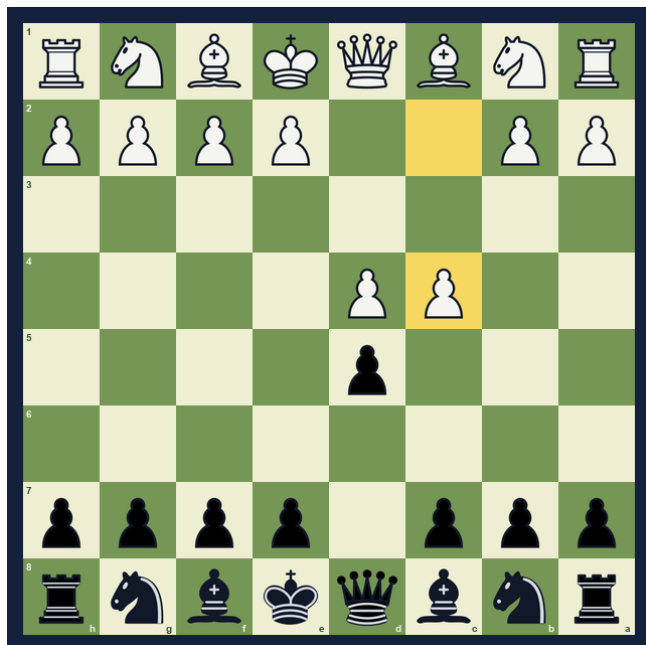
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
01 - Foundations	10
06 - Slav Defense	5
07 - Semi-Slav Defense	4

01. The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Name Black's pawn support or capture.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

E6 means QGD, d takes c4 means QGA, and c6 means Slav.

01. Decision Framework

The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.
PIECE JOB	Black takes on c4 and gives White time and central space. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not call every d4 and c4 position a Queen's Gambit after Black chooses a different central system.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not call every d4 and c4 position a Queen's Gambit after Black chooses a different central system.

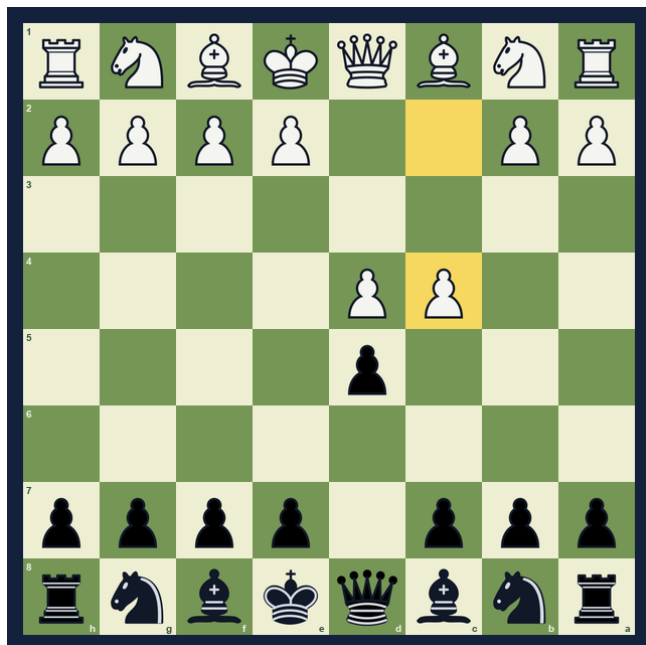
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: E6 means QGD, d takes c4 means QGA, and c6 means Slav.

02. Why the c-Pawn Is Offered



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Did Black protect, capture, or ignore c4?

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

The gambit is about deflecting d5, not donating c4.

02. Decision Framework

Why the c-Pawn Is Offered

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.
PIECE JOB	Black usually spends time trying to keep an extra wing pawn. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Trying to recover the pawn immediately can waste the development advantage that justified the gambit.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Trying to recover the pawn immediately can waste the development advantage that justified the gambit.

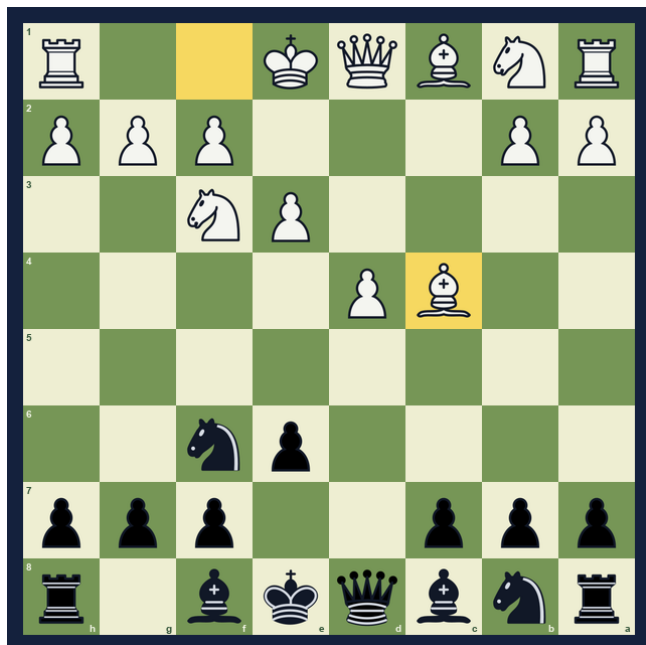
ACTIVE RECALL

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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The gambit is about deflecting d5, not donating c4.

03. How White Recovers the c4 Pawn



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Nf3 and e3 before chasing material.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Nf3, e3, Bxc4: recover the pawn by completing development.

03. Decision Framework

How White Recovers the c4 Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.
PIECE JOB	e3 opens the bishop without weakening the center. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Qa4+ may recover the pawn in some positions, but unnecessary queen moves often help Black develop.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Qa4+ may recover the pawn in some positions, but unnecessary queen moves often help Black develop.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3, e3, Bxc4: recover the pawn by completing development.

04. Do Not Rush the Central Tension



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Make useful moves while the tension remains.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Tension is stored choice; release it for a reason.

04. Decision Framework

Do Not Rush the Central Tension

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.
PIECE JOB	Black's setup reveals which exchange is most useful. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Capturing automatically may give Black an easy recapture and free development.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Capturing automatically may give Black an easy recapture and free development.

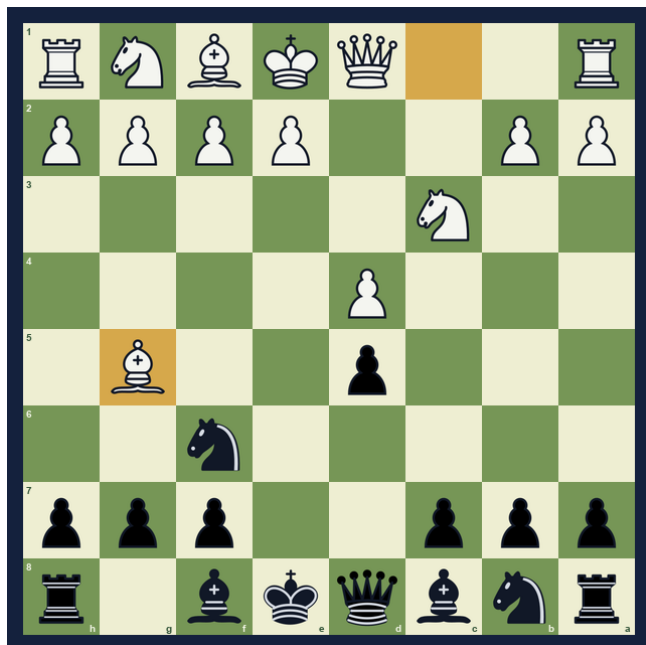
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tension is stored choice; release it for a reason.

05. When White Plays cxd5



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Choose cxd5 when you want a stable plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

cxd5 is a doorway into the Carlsbad structure, not a simplification without consequences.

05. Decision Framework

When White Plays cxd5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.
PIECE JOB	Bg5 develops before e3 closes the diagonal. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not start a minority attack before the pieces are placed to use the weaknesses it creates.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not start a minority attack before the pieces are placed to use the weaknesses it creates.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: cxd5 is a doorway into the Carlsbad structure, not a simplification without consequences.

06. When White Plays dxc5



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Develop enough pieces before changing the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A central capture is good when the forced recapture helps your development more than Black's.

06. Decision Framework

When White Plays dxc5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.
PIECE JOB	b4 attacks the bishop while gaining queenside space. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not exchange merely because the position feels tense; calculate the recapture and resulting structure.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not exchange merely because the position feels tense; calculate the recapture and resulting structure.

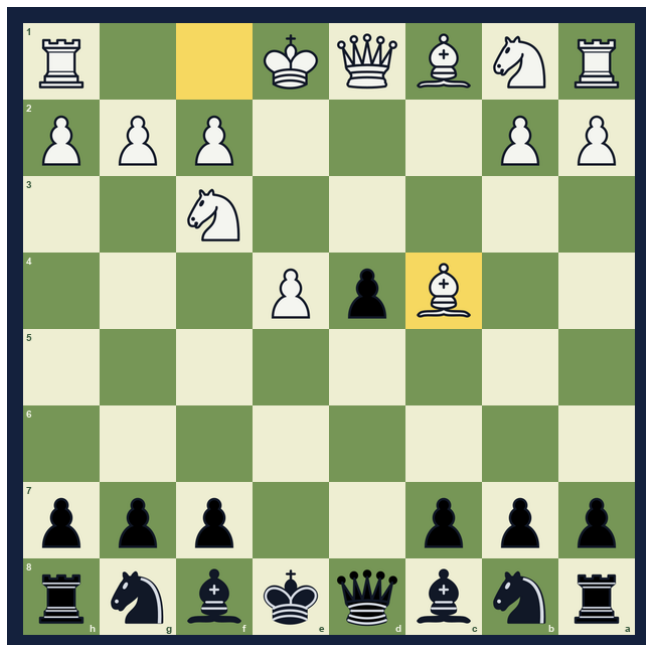
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A central capture is good when the forced recapture helps your development more than Black's.

07. The e4 Break Is White's Dream



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use e4 when Black cannot undermine it immediately.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

When d5 leaves the center, ask whether e4 can safely replace it.

07. Decision Framework

The e4 Break Is White's Dream

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.
PIECE JOB	Nf3 and Bxc4 bring pieces out with tempo. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	A large center becomes a target if White spends extra moves defending pawns instead of developing.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	A large center becomes a target if White spends extra moves defending pawns instead of developing.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When d5 leaves the center, ask whether e4 can safely replace it.

08. The Minority Attack Roadmap



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Complete the piece setup first.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Prepare, contact, fix, attack: the pawn push creates the target but does not win it by itself.

08. Decision Framework

The Minority Attack Roadmap

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.
PIECE JOB	b5 challenges c6 and forces a structural decision. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Launching b4 while the center is unstable can allow Black's e5 break to arrive first.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Launching b4 while the center is unstable can allow Black's e5 break to arrive first.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Prepare, contact, fix, attack: the pawn push creates the target but does not win it by itself.

09. Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Identify whether Black has committed to d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Move order changes the available branches, not the identity of the final position.

09. Decision Framework

Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.
PIECE JOB	After d5 and Nc3, the position becomes a QGD. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Playing automatic Nc3 against Nf6 and e6 invites Bb4 and a separate Nimzo-Indian repertoire.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Playing automatic Nc3 against Nf6 and e6 invites Bb4 and a separate Nimzo-Indian repertoire.

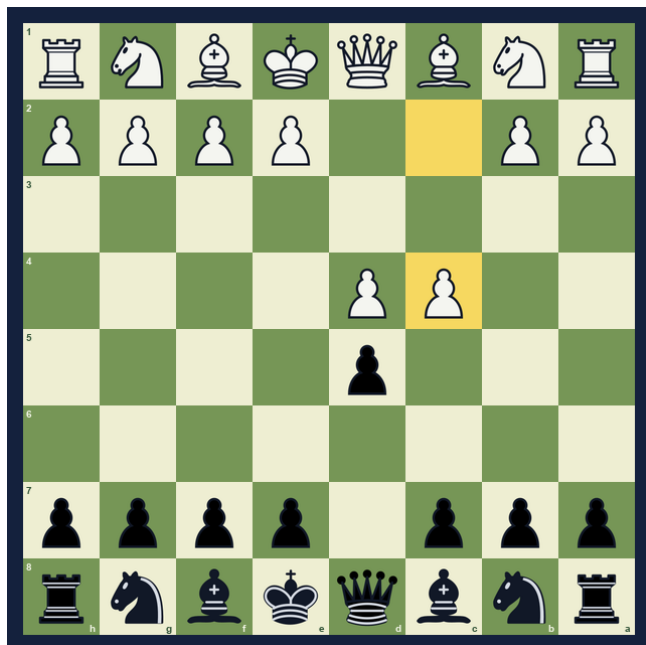
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move order changes the available branches, not the identity of the final position.

10. How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Study one short lesson.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

Moves fade; positions and purposes survive.

10. Decision Framework

How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.
PIECE JOB	Explain why each White move helps the structure. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Binge-watching theory produces recognition without recall and feels stronger than it is.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Binge-watching theory produces recognition without recall and feels stronger than it is.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Moves fade; positions and purposes survive.

11. Slav Main Line with a4



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

White uses a4 to prevent Black from comfortably holding c4 with b5, then regains the pawn and develops normally.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Bf5: Black solves the light-bishop problem before e6.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Bxc4 once b5 is prevented.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

Against the main Slav, a4 stops b5; e3 and Bxc4 finish the recovery.

11. Decision Framework

Slav Main Line with a4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White uses a4 to prevent Black from comfortably holding c4 with b5, then regains the pawn and develops normally.
PIECE JOB	a4 prevents comfortable ...b5, while Bxc4 and Qe2 help White complete development without losing control of e4.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not lose development time attacking Bf5 repeatedly.
TRADE FILTER	Bishop exchanges are favorable when they reduce Black's active light-squared play without surrendering control of e4.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Recover c4 through development, castle, and use the space gained by a4 to keep Black's queenside pieces restricted. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not lose development time attacking Bf5 repeatedly.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the main Slav, a4 stops b5; e3 and Bxc4 finish the recovery.

12. Slav Geller Gambit Setup



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Against Na6, White uses e4 to occupy the center while Black's knight is offside, creating active piece play for the pawn structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and pressures the center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Bxc4, O-O, and Be3 behind the broad center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Na6 6. e4 Bg4 7. Bxc4 e6 8. O-O Be7 9. Be3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Na6 gives White time for e4, but only rapid development makes the center strong.

12. Decision Framework

Slav Geller Gambit Setup

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Against Na6, White uses e4 to occupy the center while Black's knight is offside, creating active piece play for the pawn structure.
PIECE JOB	The broad center requires every piece to develop quickly; the a6-knight and g4-bishop are targets only when tempo permits.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push e5 and d5 before pieces are ready.
TRADE FILTER	Material recovery is secondary to keeping active bishops and central control; do not trade them just to regain c4 immediately.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central space to finish development, castle and force Black's awkward pieces to spend more time reorganizing. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push e5 and d5 before pieces are ready.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Na6 gives White time for e4, but only rapid development makes the center strong.

13. Chebanenko Slav with a6



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Black prepares b5 with a6; White closes the queenside with c5 and uses the extra space to restrict Black's pieces.

PRIMARY PLAN

...b5: Black expands and attacks the closed chain.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Control e5 and b6 so Black lacks a clean break.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 a6 5. c5 Bf5 6. Bf4 Nbd7 7. e3 Nh5 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nxc3 11. hxg3 Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Chebanenko: c5 gains space; then stop e5 and b6 before maneuvering.

13. Decision Framework

Chebanenko Slav with a6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black prepares b5 with a6; White closes the queenside with c5 and uses the extra space to restrict Black's pieces.
PIECE JOB	The f4-bishop and c5-pawn gain space, while White must watch that the queenside does not become overextended.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not let the f4 bishop run out of safe squares.
TRADE FILTER	Keep the active f4-bishop unless its exchange creates a lasting weakness; do not retreat it repeatedly without gaining something.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize c5, complete development and choose the correct central moment before Black undermines the pawn chain. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not let the f4 bishop run out of safe squares.

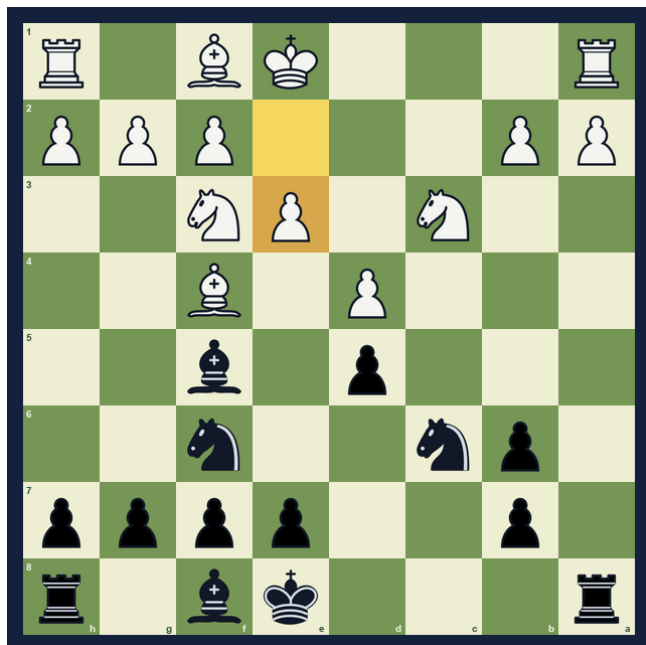
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Chebanenko: c5 gains space; then stop e5 and b6 before maneuvering.

14. Slav 4...Bf5 Pressure Line



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Black develops Bf5 before e6; White exchanges the center and uses Qb3 to force structural concessions or queen exchanges.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Qb6: Black defends b7 and offers a queen exchange.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Bf4, e3, and Bb5 to exploit the slight lead.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. cxd5 cxd5 6. Qb3 Qb6 7. Qxb6 axb6 8. Bf4 Nc6 9. e3

MEMORY RULE

Against early Bf5, cxd5 and Qb3 turn development time into structural pressure.

14. Decision Framework

Slav 4...Bf5 Pressure Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops Bf5 before e6; White exchanges the center and uses Qb3 to force structural concessions or queen exchanges.
PIECE JOB	Qb3 pressures b7 and d5, while Bf4 develops with tempo toward an endgame where Black's queenside structure matters.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not call b6 weak unless pieces can attack it.
TRADE FILTER	A queen trade on b6 is welcome only when the doubled b-pawns or development lead remains meaningful in the endgame.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use superior development to fix the queenside pawns, then improve the king and rooks before trying to win one. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not call b6 weak unless pieces can attack it.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against early Bf5, cxd5 and Qb3 turn development time into structural pressure.

15. Slav Early dxc4 Pawn Hold



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 before developing the knight and supports it with b5; White attacks the pawn chain with a4 and b3.

PRIMARY PLAN

...b5: Black tries to preserve the extra pawn.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use a4 and b3 to break the queenside chain.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. b3 cxb3 7. Qxb3 a6 8. Ba3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Early Slav pawn hold: a4 attacks b5, b3 attacks c4, development finishes the job.

15. Decision Framework

Slav Early dxc4 Pawn Hold

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black takes c4 before developing the knight and supports it with b5; White attacks the pawn chain with a4 and b3.
PIECE JOB	White's queen, bishop and a-pawn work together against the b5-c4 chain while development continues.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not expect a4 alone to recover the pawn.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange the light bishop if it is the cleanest piece for recovering c4 and attacking the weakened diagonal.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Undermine the queenside chain, regain the pawn with development, then use Black's weakened squares rather than hunting material. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not expect a4 alone to recover the pawn.

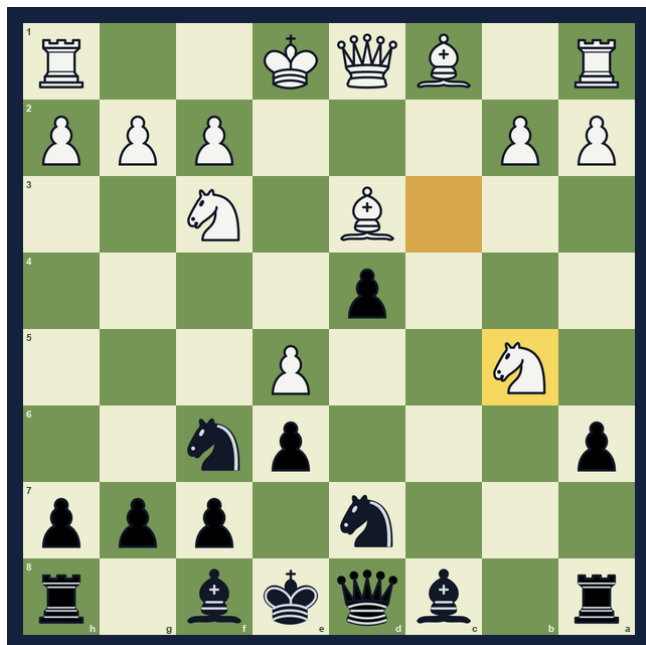
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Early Slav pawn hold: a4 attacks b5, b3 attacks c4, development finishes the job.

16. Meran Main Line



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use the development lead to gain central space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

16. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.
PIECE JOB	White's bishops and central pawns become powerful only if the king is ready for the center to open.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.
TRADE FILTER	Keep attacking pieces while the center is open, but trade a defender when that makes the e5 advance or kingside attack concrete.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central expansion to open lines, then shift from pawn play to piece play before Black consolidates. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.

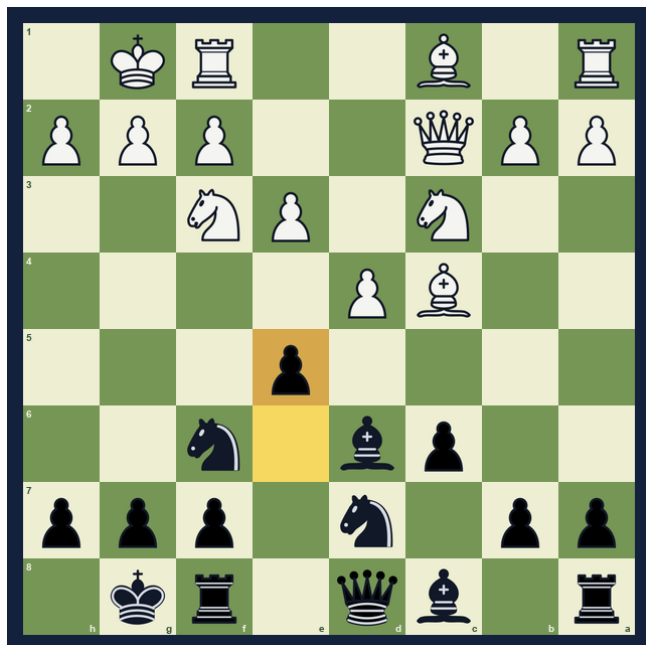
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

17. Anti-Meran with Qc2



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Bd6: Black develops toward h2 and prepares castling.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Qc2, Bd3, and O-O to support central expansion.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

17. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.
PIECE JOB	Qc2 supports e4 and keeps the bishop flexible, but White must finish development before treating the queen move as an attack.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.
TRADE FILTER	Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, coordinate rooks and use the queen's support of e4 to claim the center at the right moment. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

18. Moscow Variation



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Qxf6: Black keeps a sound structure and the bishop pair.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Bd3, O-O, and Ne4 against the exposed queen.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

18. Decision Framework

Moscow Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.
PIECE JOB	Bxf6 reduces Black's kingside activity, but White must use the time to complete development and challenge the center.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.
TRADE FILTER	Trading the g5-bishop for the f6-knight is justified by reduced counterplay and tempo, not by a universal bishop-for-knight rule.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Develop Bd3, castle and use the calmer position to apply pressure before Black's bishops become fully active. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

19. Anti-Moscow Gambit



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.

PRIMARY PLAN

...g5: Black gains the bishop pair and kingside space at structural cost.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Be2, O-O, and Qc2 before recovering material.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Anti-Moscow: preserve the bishop, build e4, castle, then use Black's loosened king.

19. Decision Framework

Anti-Moscow Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.
PIECE JOB	White's center and active bishops compensate for the pawn only if development remains faster than Black's consolidation.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend tempi chasing c4 while Black's king is vulnerable.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid exchanging attacking pieces unless the trade wins back material or leaves a lasting structural gain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, activate rooks and convert the development lead into open lines before attempting to recover every pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not spend tempi chasing c4 while Black's king is vulnerable.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Anti-Moscow: preserve the bishop, build e4, castle, then use Black's loosened king.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.